XVI—A Mighty Death

‘Bid the druggist close his shop,
I’ve tried his drugs a thousand times.’

– Akbarnama

Three years remained between Abul Fazl’s death and Akbar’s own. They were crowded with incident, like the previous forty-seven years of Akbar’s reign, or, in fact, the previous sixty years of his life. But now, it was no longer soaring tales of conquest that filled the annals, no longer the coming of the Mahdi that preoccupied Akbar. The drama had become decidedly domestic.

There is a famous portrait of Salim holding a painting of his aged father.[1] Akbar’s son was notoriously finicky about accuracy in the art he patronized. The Akbar in Salim’s hands is an old man. His moustache is as much of a wisp as it was when Akbar was a boy-king. His face is lined, and the skin at his throat hangs loose. For all that the yogis and doctors and astrologers had said, Akbar was nearing his end. The man who had made such wide-ranging plans for his empire, its people and its religions, its administration and its finances, now had to make a final decision: who would helm the empire after him?

In 1577, when Salim was about eight years old, Murad seven and Daniyal five, Akbar had given his sons mansabdari ranks. These ranks, 6000 for Daniyal, 7000 for Murad and 10,000 for the eldest, Salim, were higher than anything his officials could aspire to – the highest rank for an amir was fixed at 5000 – but the very induction of the princes into the mansabdari fold made one thing very clear: as Akbar’s warlords would no longer be allowed independent fiefs, neither would his sons. This was a radical departure from the ‘unspoken rule’ of Mughal succession – as Munis Faruqui demonstrates brilliantly in *The Princes of the Mughal Empire* – ‘. . . that every son had an equal share in his father’s patrimony and all males within a ruling group had the right to succeed to the throne’.[2] It was the rule, for example, that Babur followed when he left Hindustan to Humayun and Kabul to Kamran. It was the rule that Akbar’s half-brother, Hakim, had recourse to in keeping an independent hold over Kabul and even, as Faruqui argues elsewhere, in his bids for Lahore. It was Kamran, from Kabul, who